

Beyond disenfranchized grief: Survey and interview accounts of animal loss through and beyond COVID-19 in the United Kingdom

Elizabeth Peel & Damien W. Riggs

To cite this article: Elizabeth Peel & Damien W. Riggs (10 Sep 2025): Beyond disenfranchized grief: Survey and interview accounts of animal loss through and beyond COVID-19 in the United Kingdom, *Death Studies*, DOI: [10.1080/07481187.2025.2557716](https://doi.org/10.1080/07481187.2025.2557716)

To link to this article: <https://doi.org/10.1080/07481187.2025.2557716>



© 2025 The Author(s). Published with license by Taylor & Francis Group, LLC.



[View supplementary material](#)



Published online: 10 Sep 2025.



[Submit your article to this journal](#)



Article views: 1385



[View related articles](#)



[View Crossmark data](#)



Citing articles: 3 [View citing articles](#)

Beyond disenfranchized grief: Survey and interview accounts of animal loss through and beyond COVID-19 in the United Kingdom

Elizabeth Peel^a and Damien W. Riggs^b

^aCentre for Research in Communication and Culture, School of Social Sciences and Humanities, Loughborough University, UK; ^bCollege of Education, Psychology and Social Work, Flinders University, Australia

ABSTRACT

Although there was a rapidly growing body of literature on human-animal relationships during the COVID-19 pandemic, little attention was given to accounts of animal death through and beyond COVID-19. This paper reports on two connected studies undertaken after the end of COVID-19 restrictions in the United Kingdom, here focusing specifically on animal companion loss. From an online survey of 667 participants, 354 responded to an open-ended question about the loss of an animal. Content analysis of these data found participants commented about the timing of loss, how the loss occurred, and how they framed or accounted for the loss. From online interviews with 41 participants, 36 spoke about the loss of an animal. Themes of anticipatory grief, pandemic loss, and depth of connection were generated. The paper concludes by reconceptualizing animal bereavement to decenter human exceptionalism, and how this could further normalize the significance of animal loss.

In this paper we contribute to the existing literature focused specifically on animal companion bereavement (e.g., Hughes & Lewis Harkin, 2025; Leonhardt-Parr & Rumble, 2024; Weisman, 1991) by extending the field beyond the usual focus on disenfranchized grief (see Park et al., 2023). Although we acknowledge that some people's grief over the loss of an animal may be disenfranchized, this only tells part of the story. Adding to this, we ask whether grief over an animal is necessarily simply disenfranchized, or whether it is also understood in ways specific to the human-animal bond. In terms of grievability, Redmalm (2015) suggests that the loss of an animal companion potentially disrupts the binary of animal and human. Grieving the death of an animal considered to be part of the family elevates certain animals to the status of personhood, or at least to the status of a life that is worthy of recognition in death.

In terms of the natural death of an animal, this typically occurs due to animal aging and/or chronic health issues. Although the natural death of an animal is ultimately a cause of grief for many humans, there can also be relief for animal caregivers who have experienced additional burdens due to caring for an animal living with a chronic illness (Christiansen et al., 2013). The death of an animal can be particularly challenging for

older people, who may be reliant upon animals for company, or as avenues for connectedness with other humans. The death of an animal can result in decreases in physical activity and emotional wellbeing for older adults especially (Brown et al., 2023). By contrast, childhood experiences of the loss of an animal can be long-lasting, such that the memory of animals who were loved family members can remain with children well into adulthood (Kaufman & Kaufman, 2006).

Of course, given the power differential between humans and animals, animals who live within the home may not only die from natural causes. Humans also make decisions about the death of an animal (Wong et al., 2017). Decisions about ending the life of an animal companion can bring significant distress for many humans (Bussolari et al., 2018), however some researchers have suggested that humans who decide to end the life of an animal ultimately experience less grief than do those whose animal companion dies due to natural causes (McCutcheon & Fleming, 2002). This might suggest that when humans can make decisions about the death of an animal this brings with it a greater sense of control over associated grief. Moreover, although the natural death of an animal might lead to disenfranchized grief (because,

CONTACT Elizabeth Peel  e.peel@lboro.ac.uk  Centre for Research in Communication and Culture, School of Social Sciences and Humanities, Loughborough University, UK.

 Supplemental data for this article can be accessed online at <https://doi.org/10.1080/07481187.2025.2557716>.

© 2025 The Author(s). Published with license by Taylor & Francis Group, LLC.

This is an Open Access article distributed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivatives License (<http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/4.0/>), which permits non-commercial re-use, distribution, and reproduction in any medium, provided the original work is properly cited, and is not altered, transformed, or built upon in any way. The terms on which this article has been published allow the posting of the Accepted Manuscript in a repository by the author(s) or with their consent.

for example, other people view animal death as inevitable), the planned death of an animal might be less likely to be disenfranchised because it is recognized as a difficult decision that humans must make.

Although there is a rapidly growing body of research documenting human-animal relationships during and beyond COVID-19 restrictions (Brooks & Greenberg, 2023), to date little attention has been paid to how humans navigated the death of an animal during COVID-19 restrictions, and more broadly how COVID-19 restrictions potentially compounded or reignited past grief about the loss of an animal. In this paper we take up the topic of the death of an animal companion through an exploration of data collected in two interconnected studies (online survey and interviews) undertaken in the United Kingdom following the lifting of COVID-19 restrictions in 2022.

For most people living in the United Kingdom, COVID-19 restrictions meant a considerable loss of movement outside of the home, though humans who lived with animals were still able to walk their animal companions (King, 2022). Animal companions thus became an important source of support for many humans (e.g., Peel, 2025), and also a significant reason for why humans could leave the home for brief periods of time. Research has found that there was indeed a surge in animal adoptions in the early periods of the COVID-19 pandemic, but that this has subsequently abated, and indeed that many animals have since been abandoned (Ho et al., 2021). Exploring what animal companions meant for people living in the United Kingdom during COVID-19 restrictions is thus important. And as is the case in terms of the research question for the present paper specifically, exploring how people apprehend the loss of an animal before, during, and after COVID-19 restrictions is vital to better understanding how humans adjust to the loss of an animal companion during challenging times.

Study 1: Online survey

Method

Participants

A total of 667 people completed the survey, however given all survey items were optional, items do not necessarily sum to the total. As outlined in [supplementary material 1](#), the average participant was a woman, living in East Midlands, who was neither trans nor born with an intersex variation, was not living with a disability, was heterosexual, married, and living with a partner, was employed full time, was white, had a household income of between £33,000 and £50,999, had a higher education degree, and was

omnivorous. The average age of participants was 50.30 years ($SD=13.18$, Range = 18–83), and the average degree of religiosity was ‘somewhat religious’ ($M=1.45$, $SD=0.70$).

In terms of animal demographics, and as outlined in [supplementary Table 2](#), over half of the sample had lost an animal at some point in their life. In terms of living animals, other than living with at least one dog (an inclusion criterion), the greatest number of participants also lived with a cat, did not live with an assistance animal, considered their focus dog to be a family pet, reported that their focus dog was well trained, did not have health issues, and did not have behavioral issues. The average age of focus dogs was 4.19 years ($SD=1.28$, Range = 1–8). There were only statistically significant differences between participants who had lost an animal and those who had not in terms of animal health issues and animal behavioral issues. Participants who had lost an animal were more likely to report both health and behavioral issues for their focus dog than would be expected in an even distribution.

Materials and procedure

Ethics approval was granted by Loughborough University School of Social Sciences and Humanities Ethics Committee (Project ID: 8354). Participation was open to people living in the United Kingdom, aged 18 years or older, cohabitating with at least one dog (participants could also be living with other animals). The call for participants for the online survey was shared widely on social media and radio, and by organizations including Dogs4Rescue, Canicross UK, Oak Tree Animals’ Charity, and Save our Spaniels Rescue. Participants were not remunerated for their time. The opening screen of the online survey included a full information sheet, after which participants were asked to give consent.

The survey, designed by the first author, was hosted on Online Surveys (formerly Bristol Online Surveys) and explored participants’ perspectives on the topic of living with dogs through COVID-19. The electronic survey opened by asking participants to provide demographic information about themselves: region of residence, age, gender, whether or not they were trans, whether or not they were born with intersex characteristics, whether they were living with a disability, sexuality, relationship status, who they cohabited with, employment status, ethnicity, household income, highest educational qualification, diet, and degree of religiosity (1 = not at all religious to 4 = very religious). Participants were also asked to provide demographic details about their dog (if they lived with more than one dog and/or other animals, participants were asked to focus on one dog in responding to these questions in order to gain in-depth insight into the predominant human-canine relationship): are they an assistance animal, are they a family pet, are they well trained, do

they have health issues, and do they have behavioral issues. Participants were also asked if they had experienced the loss of an animal and were asked to respond to an open-ended question describing this loss. The online survey opened after the lifting of COVID-19 restrictions in the United Kingdom in April 2022 and ran until the end of May 2022.

Reflexivity

Both authors have had the personal experience of death of their canine companions (see further Peel et al., 2025) and also the deaths of significant human family members. We are both trained psychotherapists as well as academics, and the first author has volunteered for a national bereavement charity which excludes animal loss as legitimate grounds for accessing support. We approach this and all our research as critical psychologists interested in fostering positive social change for vulnerable and marginalized groups.

Analytic approach

Responses to the demographic questions and open-ended question were exported into IBM SPSS v26.0. Content analysis was used to analyze the survey open-ended question pertaining to the loss of an animal. As outlined by Hsieh and Shannon (2005), this involves (a) repeated readings of the data corpus, (b) developing codes by highlighting key words that capture frequently occurring concepts, (c) reducing codes in order to minimize overlaps, (d) examining codes for patterned responses, in order to group codes into categories, and examining categories to determine whether or not they accurately reflect the data corpus.

In terms of the specific undertakings of the content analysis, the second author read through each open-ended response, inductively making note of potential codes from each response. This initial coding was used to generate a list of all possible codes. All responses were then read again by the first author, allocating one code to each response. Where more than one potential code was possible for a response, the code allocated represented the most salient code within the response, based on the greatest amount of text written (i.e., if a response included two possible codes, the length of text for a given code was used to determine if it was likely the most salient code). 92% of responses contained only one possible code.

Results

Content analysis codes

From the content analysis, a total of eight codes were developed, nested under three distinct categories, as

outlined in Table 1. In terms of inferential statistics, statistical associations were found between some of the categories and demographic variables. Those who described their account of the loss as heartbreaking were more likely to be older, and those who described the loss as inevitable were more likely to be younger, $F(df=2, 93)6.601, p=.002$. Those who provided a historical account of a loss were more likely to be younger, and those who described a loss that occurred during COVID-19 lockdowns were more likely to be older, $t(df=1, 49)=2.639, p=.006$.

Content analysis description

In terms of the first category (Timing of Loss), some participants primarily wrote about the loss of an animal in terms of when it happened. The majority of these discussed a historical loss, typically one that happened during childhood. One participant wrote “I lost a dog as a kid 4years old to cancer, still dream about them now” (36, man). Another participant wrote “I grew up with a collie that was the same age as me. He had to be put down when we were both 14 - it was far more upsetting than any human death in my family since” (38, man). Examples such as these highlight that the loss of an animal can have long-lasting effects.

A smaller number of participants wrote about the loss of an animal during COVID-restrictions, losses that were often compounded by the restrictions in place at the time. For example, one participant wrote “I lost my old Jack Russell during the first lockdown and had to hand him over in a car park to a vet in full PPE, very distressing that I couldn’t be with him to say goodbye and comfort him” (66, woman). Another participant wrote that:

We lost our Jack Russell through covid. It was awful. We were not allowed to both stay with her. They put [the] needle in without us there. We were only allowed to go in at end of [the] procedure. I felt robbed of comforting my dog and friend during her last minutes when she was most scared and needed me the most. It was highly traumatic (41, woman).

For participants such as these, COVID-19 restrictions had a significant impact both on the death of their

Table 1. Content analysis codes.

Category	Code	N
Timing of loss	Historical loss	39
	COVID-specific account	11
Type of loss	Euthanasia	94
	Accidental death	9
	Old age/natural death	105
Account of loss	Death is inevitable due to lifespan	7
	Heartbroken	66
	Replacement animal	21

animal, but also on how they were able to grieve the death.

In terms of the second category (Type of Loss), participants spoke about one of three forms of death. Most common were responses about the death of an animal due to old age or 'natural causes' (i.e., an animal who died from an illness). For example, "Lost my dog to old age in 2019. It broke my heart and took me almost a year to come to terms with" (51, woman). Another participant wrote "Lost an elderly dog. Very sad and the remaining dogs were unsettled at first and their relationship with each other changed" (43, woman). Even when mindful of the differences between human and animal lifespans, the death of an animal had a significant impact upon many participants, and as the second quote suggests, had significant repercussions on other animals living in the home. Other participants spoke about making the difficult decision to euthanise an animal who was suffering: "My old dog had a stroke and was put down in the second month of shutdown in 2020. It was obviously devastating and I was extremely lost" (69, woman). Of note here is the language used: was put down rather than I put him down, a common way that euthanasia was described. Of course, this type of distancing language is a way people potentially manage their involvement in a decision that has caused them grief. Other participants did acknowledge euthanasia as their decision, often noting regret or indecision about this action: "I lost my other dog Charlie, at the age of 13, because of his very ill health I made the decision to have him euthanised - I'm not sure if it was the right decision and I will regret that decision till the day I die" (39, woman). Finally, a small number of participants noted that they had lost an animal due to an accident: "Friend ran over my dog" (57, woman) and "My old family dog died due to rat poison scattered around a field that is frequently visited by families with young children and pets" (38, woman). Although humans may be prepared for the loss of an animal given awareness of differing lifespans for humans as compared to animals, a sudden unexpected loss presents a challenge to a normatively expected lifespan.

Regarding the final category (Account of Loss), participants who disclosed how they understood or accounted for the loss of an animal companion primarily wrote about feeling heartbroken. For example: "Even though I knew it was time to let him go, it was heartbreaking. The sense of loss was enormous" (67, woman), and "Absolutely devastating - it was the worst pain and heartache since losing my Mum. Our girlie Springer was heartbroken too" (61, woman). In

the second quote loss of a human and loss of an animal are directly compared, and it is also acknowledged that other animals can experience heartbreak too. A small number of participants emphasized the shorter lifespan of animals, and in a way potentially minimized the death of an animal: "It's hard losing a pet especially a dog but it is inevitable because of their life span" (72, woman). Obviously, there is recognition of loss in this quote, but the loss is viewed as inevitable. Finally, several participants indicated that they had dealt with the loss of an animal companion by bringing another animal into their household: "We lost our dog when we were renovating a house, so agreed to wait to adopt another. We lasted 3 weeks! The unwelcome freedom was awful" (52, woman). Here it is of note that although we use the language of 'replacement' for this code, this is not to suggest that the loss was not felt. Rather, the point as evidenced in this quote, is that it was living without an animal that was equally distressing.

Study 2: Online interviews

Method

Participants

In terms of interview participants, 30 (73%) were women and 11 were men. The majority (N=29, 71%) reported that they were heterosexual, with other participants reporting that they were lesbian, gay, queer, pansexual, or bisexual. Most too were partnered or married (N=28, 68%) with the remainder single, divorced or widowed. The average age of participants was 53 years (range 27–77 years), and all participants were white aside from one who was British Indian. In terms of country/region of the UK those from the East Midlands (N=11, 27%) were most represented followed by the West Midlands (N=7, 17%), London (N=6, 15%), East of England (N=5, 12%), North West of England (N=4, 10%), Scotland (N=3, 7%), South West of England (N=2, 5%) and one participant from the South East of England, Yorkshire, and Northern Ireland. Most participants currently had one dog (N=30, 73%) with five having two, four having three, and two participants having four and five dogs respectively. The average age of the dogs was 6.21 years (range 9 months–14 years) and they were small (e.g., Chihuahua, Yorkshire Terrier), medium (e.g., Cockerpoo, Beagle) and larger (e.g., Golden Retriever, Belgian Malinois) (see Peel & Slocombe, 2022 for further detail). Interviewee and dog names have been pseudonymised.

Materials and procedure

Ethics approval was granted by Loughborough University School of Social Sciences and Humanities Ethics Committee (Project ID: 8354). A project website was developed, which was used to disseminate the call for interview participants. This second call was also shared widely on social media, and physically in the form of flyers posted at dog parks, dog groomers, and handed out by the first author to people walking in public spaces with dogs. Participants were not remunerated for their time. For the interviews, participants were provided with an information sheet and were asked to digitally sign a consent form. Participation was open to people living in the United Kingdom, aged 18 years or older, cohabitating with at least one dog (participants could also be living with other animals).

Interviews, conducted by the first author, all took place online via Microsoft Teams. Sample interview questions include “Please tell me about your everyday life with your dog” and “Please tell me about how you and your dog communicate,” with the following question being the focus of the present paper: “If you have ever lost a dog can you tell me what happened and how this affected you and your family,” with a specific prompt question about what the experience was like if it happened during COVID-19. Interviews were video recorded via Teams and transcribed automatically within Teams, with the first author then manually amending transcripts where automatic transcription was inaccurate. Interviews lasted on average for 60 minutes and were conducted in June–September 2022.

Analytic approach

The interview data were analyzed using reflexive thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2022). Data from the 36 (88%) of interviewees who had experienced loss of a dog formed the data-set for the analysis. Following the phases of analysis discussed in detail by Braun and Clarke (2022), the coding process was both inductive and deductive and also iterative. The first author, an experienced qualitative researcher, generated an audit trail of thematic maps and journal entries throughout the process of moving from codes to overarching themes. These materials, alongside the dataset, informed a discussion between both authors; the second of whom is also experienced in qualitative analysis. The analytic process was also checked against Braun and Clarke (2024) Reflexive Thematic Analysis Reporting Guidelines, ensuring the analysis was fully aligned with their criteria. Both authors alighted on the final themes generated and agreed that the

“pattern of shared meaning, organized around a core concept or idea, a central organizing concept” (Braun et al., 2018, p. 845) was reflected in the final theme headings and content.

Results

Anticipatory grief

Anticipatory grief is any grief occurring before a loss rather than at or after a death. Given the shorter lifespan of animals, anticipatory grief and loss were invariably woven through interviewees’ accounts of animal loss (Cox, 2017). As Emma (46) succinctly put it “it’s inevitable, unfortunately, isn’t it ... I don’t want to think about it, but I do think about it.” As did Tricia (49) stated, “I don’t like to think about it, but at the end of the day it’s inevitable” and Tom (48) stressed “it’s inevitable ... it will hit me pretty hard” and Lucy (35) “It’s like I know it’s inevitable; they’re not gonna be with us forever.” The inescapability of loss was recognized too by those who had prior bereavements as adults. Emily (41) who had experienced four animal companion bereavements spoke of the obligations of animal companionship in dying as well as living: “It’s part and parcel of it. ... If you’re gonna look after them in life, you have to look after them in the process of dying as well.” The “inevitability” of loss did not, for these interviewees, in any way ameliorate “how hard that is” (Emily, 41) or “how devastating it will be” (Sam, 49). Rebecca (34), for instance, conveyed the anxiety around anticipatory grief as follows:

Most likely you will outlive them barring sort of major accidents. ... I think you sort of anticipate that grief a little bit... the thought of losing her is always really horrifying. Like sort of just like 2:00 am anxiety for me (Rebecca, 34)

Rebecca was not the only interviewee to talk so explicitly about anticipatory grief. Clara (56), who had a veterinary medicine background, was unequivocal that she had “a lot of sort of anticipatory grief” about one of her late dogs who had lived with several chronic conditions. Past experiences of loss were also intertwined with accounts of anticipatory grief and worry regarding a current companion animal:

It was an absolutely horrible experience to- to- yes, to lose them... It’s a huge loss and it feels like losing a member of your family... they were almost my siblings, so they would always be there to play with and share moments with.... It does affect kind of how then I project that onto Polly and my anxiety around failing Polly (Alex, 39)

Anticipatory grief and worry about future animal companion death was a predominant theme for these participants. As we explore further in the discussion, this finding interconnects with undermining anthropocentrism and human exceptionalism in studies of loss given that anticipatory grief has been thoroughly researched for *human* loss (Coelho & Barbosa, 2017; Dehpour & Koffman, 2023; Sweeting & Gilhooly, 1990). Anticipatory grief is an under-researched specter regarding companion animal lives generally and aging dogs in ‘normal’ times, but the COVID-19 pandemic provided an ‘abnormal’ context to death too. This we explore in the next theme.

Pandemic loss

As was evident from the content analysis and the extant literature, COVID-19 shaped experiences of animal companion death in particular ways, characterized by ambiguous loss and mass bereavement (Boss, 2022; Torrens-Burton et al., 2022). Charles (77), like most of the interviewees, was visibly upset when recounting the details surrounding the death of his nearly 15-year-old dog:

Charles: having nursed the dog to the end is actually quite- that’s a privilege. And although there’s lockdown.

Interviewer: Yes. Did you get to be with him?

Charles: I was waiting. And I wouldn’t have wanted it any other way. ... I think it’s that sort of experience makes you understand the trust element of owning a dog.... it sometimes makes me wonder how- you know, how I’ve been disloyal to Timmy’s memory by having another dog so quickly.

Although, for Charles, “waiting” rather than being physically present with his late dog was his preference, being with the animal at the time is typically preferred (Kogan & Cooney, 2023). COVID-19 regulations prevented many people from being present with their animal companion when they were euthanised. Clara (56) was fortunate that her colleague conducted the “emergency put to sleep” of her late dog, and so she was able to have a typical client experience. However, Clara was acutely aware of “the way that [veterinary] practices were interpreting the rules was that you couldn’t stay in the room.... they were waiting in the car and stuff like that, the same as people dying on their own or not dying with family... I think that was hard for people.” The equalization of, and parity between, human and animal bereavement which Clara draws (“the same”) was borne of the unprecedented times experienced during the pandemic. Her empathy for other human companions of animals experiencing euthanasia at this time was captured in Pam’s (58) actual experience with her Golden Labrador, Pixie:

It was the pandemic and I couldn’t go in with her. She had cancer.... Saying goodbye to her was horrible because she was just led away on the lead [through] the surgery and she stopped halfway. And she just paused, and she looked back at me, and she did a little wag of the tail, and then she turned back, and then she was definitely saying goodbye. She absolutely knew. Umm. And that was- that was hard. Not being with her because although it’s a horrible process, there’s something also quite beautiful about being with them when they go (Pam, 58)

Pam’s account of pandemic loss is contrasted with her prior experience of being with her companion animal at the end. Although, as she acknowledges it was “horrible” and “hard,” her experience was, comparatively, more of a “goodbye” than many human-only experiences of death and dying were at that time. Another vet, Gemma (56), spoke at length about the impact of the pandemic on how euthanasia was conducted:

During the first part of the pandemic, when we really were in the most serious lockdown, there were animals being put to sleep without their owners present and very very quickly, [we] found ways around that. So they were sitting in the back car park with the dogs in the car and we had a long drip line, that sort of thing because ... so many people just couldn’t go through the grieving process, having just dropped them off- off at the door. You know, the majority of people want to stay with their pets when they’re put to sleep, and so that was one of the most difficult things that we had to try and get round. (Gemma, 56)

One of the interesting features of Gemma’s recollection of COVID times is the difference in approach to physical distancing for animal and human death. In terms of animal bereavement the restrictions were something “we had to try and get round” and human-animal separation was mitigated by using outdoor spaces and different equipment. In contrast, many human deaths in the pandemic happened alone or with just professional staff present, which significantly impacted the grieving process (Hernández-Fernández & Meneses-Falcón, 2023). Therefore, pandemic loss in this context was notable in two main ways: first, that there was still an opportunity for human and animal to say goodbye in an embodied way; and second, COVID rules were modified to facilitate as good-a-death as possible in the circumstance.

Depth of connection

The depth of emotional connection to companion animals is long established in the literature. Prior to the pandemic, research particularly emphasized the importance of animal companionship and support to those humans whereby human connections were

limited, for example, older people and/or those with mental health struggles. The COVID-19 restrictions were, for most people in the United Kingdom, a leveller that elevated the human-animal bond across the board. Gemma (56) articulated this from her professional perspective:

For many people, actually they form closer bonds to their dogs than they do with most of their friends. ... I see it all the time... and especially during COVID, you know, there were people during COVID and their dogs were their lives more than, y'know they couldn't see their friends, they couldn't see their family... there were people that I worried about during COVID thinking, if you lose this dog now, you know it's really gonna seriously affect your mental health (Gemma, 56)

Keira (48) offered the most heartfelt account of the loss of her animal companion, though her emotive language was similarly reflected in other more circumspect accounts of the depth of the connection with their late animal companion. For example, respondents noted that such loss was “heartbreaking” (Diane, 52); “devastating ... they just leave a gaping hole” (Helen, 56); “hard” (Simone, 58); and “just horrendous, I think it's the most I've ever cried in my life” (Pam, 58). Keira's narrative was indicative of the depth of the connection these interviewees had with their companion animal:

I was so grief stricken... I really did feel like I was going to lose my mind with the grief of it... it was devastating it- I- nothing, y'know, I'm a woman in my 40s, I have experienced loss and grief, y'know, family members, relationships that leave... Yet nothing prepared me for how I would feel... It completely derailed me... This is literally the biggest grief, and I feel like I've lost a child (Keira, 48)

Lucy (35) expressed the depth of connection in a different way, highlighting: “The way I try and approach grief is one of privilege because it's like you don't feel grief unless there was something meaningful to grieve over.” That “the bond has been so strong” (Simon, 54) was commonly expressed by interviewees as it was viewed as “very special, especially if you've had them from a puppy” (Jan, 75):

I think on the grief spectrum, I've said to other people that are dog lovers and lost their dogs. On the grief spectrum, you've got that the worst grief is- is obviously losing a child, and then you've got the other end. You got losing a partner or parent, and to me it's somewhere in between. It sounds awful to say that it's worse than losing a parent or partner ... One of them in particular, we'd had for 14 years a Labrador, and I cried more over that than even over my parents or anybody else that's died (Jan, 75)

Interestingly, in Jan's account, she acknowledges the human exceptionalism often embedded in cultural understandings around death and dying (“It sounds awful to say...”). However, this does not undermine the strength of her animal loss grief experience actually superseding human bereavements. Moreover, this participant's conceptualization of grief as on a spectrum echoes Stroebe and Schut (1999) well established Dual Process Model (DPM), and hints at the ‘loss’ phase (“cried more...”) more than the ‘restoration’ phase.

Notions of replaceability—which could be equated with the DPM ‘restoration’ phase—were resisted by these interviewees in subtle ways, often through differentiating between the lost animal companion and a new dog. Accounts maximizing the differences between the animals or stressing their unique and special qualities—“She was the dog of a lifetime” (Pam, 58) was one such approach. For Charles (77), although his new dog was the same breed, he consciously chose a different eye and hair color although acknowledging feeling “disloyal.” Victoria (52) further emphasized the importance of differentiation and the uniqueness of each animal companion relationship: “I wanted a different breed and a different sex... because I didn't- I didn't want to compare.” And Tom (48) mused speculatively “Do you get the same breed of dog and always get reminded of him?” ultimately concluding that a “break” would be essential and that his animal companion will “literally” have been “man's best friend.” Regardless of the decision to get another animal companion ‘quickly’ or take a ‘break’—or indeed as Charles commented, “having been through that they would never want to have a dog again because they can't cope with it”—the significance of the loss was not minimized. Keira (48) expressed this in the most emotive terms of these interviewees in that she “felt like I was a traitor” getting another animal companion.

Roopa (39), by contrast, mused on whether the “void” of animal companion loss was generic or would be restricted to her two dogs as unique beings: “one of the biggest questions that plays on my mind is would I get more dogs after these two? ... When they leave the void that they leave behind, will that be able to be filled with any other dog or is it just them two and they've left this void that's specifically for Treacle and Breen.” Roopa's hypothetical musing differed from the consensus within these data that animal companions were not replaceable. The notion of replaceability complements the edifice of disenfranchised grief, in that if the loss of the animal is ameliorated with another (similar to the notion that

if a pregnancy is lost that unique loss is overwritten by a new pregnancy) then it is not a fully franchised grief. Gemma (56), a vet, most explicitly countered this position in saying:

I never think you can replace one dog with another.... The pain of losing each one it stays with you even if you've got another dog.... I always say to people don't let anybody tell you that it's not painful because it is painful and you need to just give yourself time (Gemma, 56).

Gemma's use of extreme case formulations ("never," "always," "anybody")—that is, words or phrases hearably going to extremes (Pomerantz, 1986)—construct her account in such a way as to render the assumption of a lesser or more marginal status to animal loss inconceivable.

The depth of connection was also evident in how interviewees talked about their late animal companions in familial terms. For instance, Tricia (49) said she was "like my sister, even though it's a dog.... They're always there in our hearts." And Tamsin (37) empathically and emotionally said of her late dog "she was my best friend." For Lesley (73) she had "almost that soul mate connection with him," and Deidre (63) noted "it's like losing any member of the family" as did Diane (52), who stated "it is like losing a family member, without a doubt." Familial connection was reflected too in how dogs were mourned and incorporated into the nexus of human-animal loss. For instance, Gina's (54) late Labrador and her father were intertwined in death: "Her ashes went in my Dad's coffin." And Emily (41) had given her son her late dog's name as his middle name as a form of memorialization. Gabrielle (64) too wanted her children to keep her dog's ashes so they could be physically rejoined after she had died.

Discussion: beyond disenfranchised grief?

The notion of disenfranchised grief regarding loss of a companion animal is the most prevalent concept within the existing literature (e.g., Crossley & Rolland, 2022; Hughes & Lewis Harkin, 2025; Park et al., 2023). The analysis of the interview data reported in the present paper, however, by combining discussion of anticipatory grief, pandemic loss and depth of connection, suggests that in the COVID-19 and post-pandemic bereavement landscape disenfranchised grief may no longer be the most appropriate framework for understanding animal loss (Figure 1). The findings suggest that there was parity in experience of animal loss, and in some cases animal death was

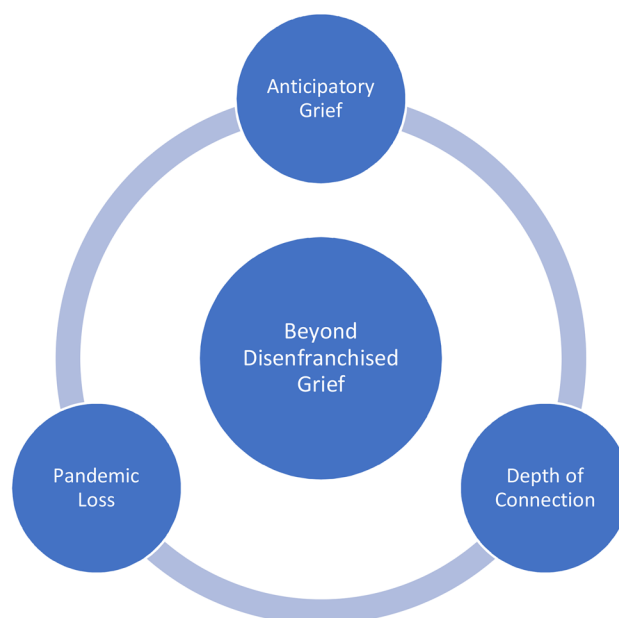


Figure 1. Thematic map.

a more dignified experience than human death during COVID-19 in the UK.

Our finding regarding the depth and breadth of anticipatory grief in interview participant accounts offers an important illustration of how decentering human exceptionalism (i.e., the belief that humans are fundamentally different from and superior to other species, e.g., Tyler, 2021) and anthropocentrism is needed in death studies. Anticipatory grief is a well-established and researched concept in human-centric terms (Dehpour & Koffman, 2023). Sweeting & Gilhooly, 1990; Early studies of anticipatory grief documented the reactions of parents of dying children (Sweeting & Gilhooly, 1990), and there is an extensive literature on familial anticipatory grief with respect to human adults dying of cancer (e.g., Coelho & Barbosa, 2017) and dementia (e.g., Dehpour & Koffman, 2023). However, social science research examining familial anticipatory grief for companion animals is limited (cf., Cox, 2017).

We have argued elsewhere (Peel, 2024) that the conditions during COVID-19 meant that human-centric losses were more widely disenfranchised. Moreover, if the concept of disenfranchised grief as a form of empathic failure "is found to some extent in nearly all grief experiences" (Neimeyer & Jordan, 2002, p.114), then the reiteration of animal loss being invariably disenfranchised in perpetuity in the literature on death and dying is de facto redundant. If it is the case that disenfranchised grief has become the 'new normal', then this should equally apply to the grievability of more-than-human losses. As Keira (48)

acknowledged; “you learn to pick your audience” with animal companion grief, or as Jan (75) remarked; “I do find the ‘them and us’ when it comes to animal grief,” meaning that she would share her grief with other dog lovers because they would be more likely to be able to empathize and understand the significance of the death. But this recognition and tailoring of disclosure is not necessarily an indicator of disenfranchized grief. Rather, disclosing ones’ experience of bereavement to the ‘right’ recipient is a hallmark of all forms of loss. When human loved ones die, for example, family members often shield each other from the depth of their grief or avoid talking openly or repeatedly to their usual support network for fear of ‘burdening’ them, hence the ubiquity of bereavement support charities and groups. With respect to animal loss, this notion of the ‘right recipient’ can be seen in the recent research engagement with pet bereavement counseling as a specific form of support (Crossley & Rolland, 2022; Leonhardt-Parr & Rumble, 2024).

When comparing the loss of a canine companion to the loss of other companion animals such as cats and hamsters, Ruth (48) remarked “I think dogs hit you a bit differently.” What Ruth is alluding to here is the special status that dogs have in many people’s lives ahead of other animal companions (Haraway, 2003), which is also reflected in dogs being the animal most frequently studied in human-animal interaction research (Gee & Wells, 2025). Thus, it depends too what the comparator is regarding loss being felt to be disenfranchized. Within normative Western understandings of animal companion bereavement, the loss of a canine animal companion is the most societally recognized.

In terms of our brief quantitative findings, these largely echo previous research, such that older participants were more likely to find the death of an animal to be heartbreaking (e.g., Brown et al., 2023). Yet at the same time, many of our younger survey participants wrote about memories of the death of an animal during childhood, similar to participants in a study by Kaufman and Kaufman (2006). These findings suggest two things: that, during the COVID-19 pandemic, older people may have been more reliant upon animal companions, and hence the death of an animal was particularly distressing for them, and that the loss and grief that we all experienced during COVID-19 restrictions may have exacerbated past grief for some people. Also both echoing and diverging from previous research (e.g., Bussolari et al., 2018; McCutcheon & Fleming, 2002), our content analysis of the open-ended survey responses found that

decisions about euthanasia were particularly challenging during COVID-19 restrictions.

Limitations

We are mindful that the findings focus on a specific moment in time, though we would note that the social landscape of human-animal relationships has changed significantly since COVID-19. We are also mindful that these data focus on the UK context, where COVID-19 restrictions were quite specific and long-lasting. Whether or not experiences of animal loss were similar or different in other geographic contexts is thus a matter for further research. Finally, it is important to note that despite some heterogeneity within the samples, there was relative racial homogeneity. Future research will benefit from focusing on cultural differences in understandings and experiences of animal-related grief.

Conclusion

Crossley and Rolland (2022, p. 6) suggest that the pandemic and the rise of virtual counseling during and since COVID-19 is generating “a possible societal shift in the recognition of grieving pet loss as a normative experience.” This conclusion sits in contrast with the general tenor of the animal companion grief literature which (re)iterates the importance of ongoing discussion of this form of bereavement “help[ing] to franchise grief experiences” (Hughes & Lewis Harkin, 2025, p. 1678) and the continuing “need to normalize and legitimize animal companion loss” (Leonhardt-Parr & Rumble, 2024, p. 375).

Conversely, this article empirically supports the supposition that during and post-pandemic there has been greater legitimacy and status afforded to animal loss bereavement, and thus disenfranchized grief may now be a limiting conceptual framework. Based on our findings, future directions for studies of animal companion bereavement and loss could include moving beyond the predominant narrative of disenfranchisement or binary notions of dis/enfranchisement. We tentatively suggest a shift in language in bereavement services and support, such that ‘grief’ when applicable to humans is labeled ‘human-centric grief’ and when concerning non-human animals is denoted ‘animal-centred grief’. This is because, ultimately, anthropocentrism underpins the continued utilization of disenfranchized grief as a totalizing lens to view non-human animal death. When applied to animal loss, disenfranchized grief reinscribes human

exceptionalism regarding death, mourning, and entitlement to grief. Our post-pandemic, increasingly nature-connected world, promises new nonhierarchical non-binary understandings of grief experiences that displace human-centrism and better honor other animals in human lives.

Acknowledgements

With grateful thanks to all the research participants and all the individuals, organisations and groups who helped promote the *Dog Talking and Walking* project (<https://wellbeingdog.wordpress.com/>). The research was supported by a University Fellowship granted to the first author. The second author would like to acknowledge that he lives on the unceded lands of the Peramangk people, and acknowledge their sovereignty as First Nations people.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Funding

The author(s) reported there is no funding associated with the work featured in this article.

References

- Boss, P. (2022). *The myth of closure: Ambiguous loss in a time of pandemic and change*. W W Norton.
- Braun, V., & Clarke, V. (2022). *Thematic analysis: A practical guide*. Sage.
- Braun, V., & Clarke, V. (2024). Supporting best practice in reflexive thematic analysis reporting in *Palliative Medicine: A review of published research and introduction to the Reflexive Thematic Analysis Reporting Guidelines* (RTARG). *Palliative Medicine*, 38(6), 608–616. <https://doi.org/10.1177/02692163241234800>
- Braun, V., Clarke, V., Terry, G., & Hayfield, N. (2018). Thematic analysis. In P. Liamputtong (Ed.), *Handbook of research methods in health and social sciences* (pp. 843–860). Springer.
- Brooks, S. K., & Greenberg, N. (2023). The well-being of companion animal caregivers and their companion animals during the COVID-19 pandemic: Scoping review. *Animals: An Open Access Journal from MDPI*, 13(20), 3294. <https://doi.org/10.3390/ani13203294>
- Brown, C. A., Wilson, D. M., Carr, E., Gross, D. P., Miciak, M., & Wallace, J. E. (2023). Older adults and companion animal death: A survey of bereavement and disenfranchised grief. *Human-Animal Interactions*. <https://doi.org/10.1079/hai.2023.0017>
- Bussolari, C. J., Habarth, J., Katz, R., Phillips, S., Carmack, B., & Packman, W. (2018). The euthanasia decision-making process: A qualitative exploration of bereaved companion animal owners. *Bereavement Care*, 37(3), 101–108. <https://doi.org/10.1080/02682621.2018.1542571>
- Christiansen, S. B., Kristensen, A. T., Sandøe, P., & Lassen, J. (2013). Looking after chronically ill dogs: Impacts on the caregiver's life. *Anthrozoös*, 26(4), 519–533. <https://doi.org/10.2752/175303713X13795775536174>
- Coelho, A., & Barbosa, A. (2017). Family anticipatory grief: An integrative literature review. *The American Journal of Hospice & Palliative Care*, 34(8), 774–785. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1049909116647960>
- Cox, S. (2017). Anticipatory grief and preparation for pet loss. In M. Gardner & D. McVety (Eds.), *Treatment and care of the geriatric veterinary patient* (pp. 311–315). Wiley.
- Crossley, M. K., & Rolland, C. (2022). Overcoming the social stigma of losing a pet: Considerations for counseling professions. *Human-Animal Interactions*. <https://doi.org/10.1079/hai.2022.0022>
- Dehpour, T., & Koffman, J. (2023). Assessment of anticipatory grief in informal caregivers of dependants with dementia: A systematic review. *Aging & Mental Health*, 27(1), 110–123. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13607863.2022.2032599>
- Gee, N. R., & Wells, D. L. (2025). Examining the trajectory of human–animal interaction research: Past, present, and future. In A.H. Fine, M.K. Mueller, Z.Y. Ng, T.C. Griffin, & P. Tedeschi (Eds.), *Handbook on animal-assisted therapy* (6th ed., pp. 83–94). Academic Press. <https://doi.org/10.1016/B978-0-443-22346-4.00006-8>
- Haraway, D. (2003). *The companion species manifesto: Dogs, people, and significant others*. Prickly Paradigm Press.
- Hernández-Fernández, C., & Meneses-Falcón, C. (2023). Nobody should die alone. Loneliness and a dignified death during the COVID-19 pandemic. *Omega*, 88(2), 550–569. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00302228211048316>
- Ho, J., Hussain, S., & Sparagano, O. (2021). Did the COVID-19 pandemic spark a public interest in pet adoption? *Frontiers in Veterinary Science*, 8, 647308. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fvets.2021.647308>
- Hsieh, H. F., & Shannon, S. E. (2005). Three approaches to qualitative content analysis. *Qualitative Health Research*, 15(9), 1277–1288. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1049732305276687>
- Hughes, B., & Lewis Harkin, B. (2025). The impact of continuing bonds between pet owners and their pets following the death of their pet: A systematic narrative synthesis. *Omega*, 90(4), 1666–1684. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00302228221125955>
- Kaufman, K. R., & Kaufman, N. D. (2006). And then the dog died. *Death Studies*, 30(1), 61–76. <https://doi.org/10.1080/07481180500348811>
- King, S. (2022). Of companionship, curfew, and conflict: Multispecies leisure in the age of COVID. *Leisure Studies*, 41(3), 301–309. <https://doi.org/10.1080/02614367.2021.1989018>
- Kogan, L. R., & Cooney, K. A. (2023). Defining a “good death”: Exploring veterinarians’ perceptions of companion animal euthanasia. *Animals*, 13(13), 2117. <https://doi.org/10.3390/ani13132117>
- Leonhardt-Parr, E., & Rumble, B. (2024). Coping with animal companion loss: A thematic analysis of pet bereavement counselling. *Omega*, 89(1), 362–378. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00302228211073217>
- McCutcheon, K. A., & Fleming, S. J. (2002). Grief resulting from euthanasia and natural death of companion animals. *OMEGA - Journal of Death and Dying*, 44(2), 169–188. <https://doi.org/10.2190/5QG0-HVH8-JED0-ML16>

- Neimeyer, R. A., & Jordan, J. R. (2002). Disenfranchisement as empathic failure: Grief therapy and the co-construction of meaning. In K.J. Doka (Ed) *Disenfranchised grief: New directions, challenges, and strategies for practice*. (pp. 95–117) Research Press.
- Park, R. M., Royal, K. D., & Gruen, M. E. (2023). A literature review: Pet bereavement and coping mechanisms. *Journal of Applied Animal Welfare Science: JAAWS*, 26(3), 285–299. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10888705.2021.1934839>
- Peel, E. (2024). Has disenfranchised grief become the ‘new normal’? *The Person-Centred Quarterly*, Winter, 54–60.
- Peel, E. (2025). An antidote to “armageddon and potential doom”: Accounts of canine-human companionship during COVID. *Qualitative Research in Psychology*, 22(1), 56–80. <https://doi.org/10.1080/14780887.2024.2364321>
- Peel, E., Riggs, D. W., & Taylor, N. (2025). Love, loss and animals: A posthumanist account of dementia in multi-species kinship. In N. Jenkins, A. Jack-Waugh & L. Ritchie (Eds.) *Multi-species dementia studies: Towards an interdisciplinary approach* (pp. 171–200) Policy Press. <https://doi.org/10.51952/9781447368823.ch005>
- Peel, E., & Slocombe, F. (2022). *Dog Talking and Walking Survey: Findings Summary* [Unpublished Report]. Loughborough University <https://wellbeingdog.wordpress.com/2022/10/31/survey-findings-summary/>
- Pomerantz, A. (1986). Extreme case formulations: A way of legitimizing claims. *Human Studies*, 9(2-3), 219–229. <https://doi.org/10.1007/BF00148128>
- Redmalm, D. (2015). Pet grief: When is non-human life grievable? *The Sociological Review*, 63(1), 19–35. <https://doi.org/10.1111/1467-954X.12226>
- Stroebe, M., & Schut, H. (1999). The dual process model of coping with bereavement: Rationale and description. *Death Studies*, 23(3), 197–224. <https://doi.org/10.1080/074811899201046>
- Sweeting, H. N., & Gilhooly, M. L. M. (1990). Anticipatory grief: A review. *Social Science & Medicine* (1982), 30(10), 1073–1080. [https://doi.org/10.1016/0277-9536\(90\)90293-2](https://doi.org/10.1016/0277-9536(90)90293-2)
- Torrens-Burton, A., Goss, S., Sutton, E., Barawi, K., Longo, M., Seddon, K., Carduff, E., Farnell, D. J. J., Nelson, A., Byrne, A., Phillips, R., Selman, L. E., & Harrop, E. (2022). ‘It was brutal. It still is’: A qualitative analysis of the challenges of bereavement during the COVID-19 pandemic reported in two national surveys. *Palliative Care and Social Practice*, 16, 26323524221092456. <https://doi.org/10.1177/26323524221092456>
- Tyler, T. (2021). The exception and the norm: Dimensions of anthropocentrism. In S. McHugh, R. McKay & J. Miller (Eds.), *The Palgrave handbook of animals and literature*. Palgrave Macmillan. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-39773-9_2
- Weisman, A. D. (1991). Bereavement and companion animals. *OMEGA - Journal of Death and Dying*, 22(4), 241–248. <https://doi.org/10.2190/C54Y-UGMH-QGR4-CWTL>
- Wong, P. W., Lau, K. C., Liu, L. L., Yuen, G. S., & Wing-Lok, P. (2017). Beyond recovery: Understanding the post bereavement growth from companion animal loss. *Omega*, 75(2), 103–123. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0030222815612603>